2.6.2 Key first-generation drone models

2.6.2.1 Aerial Target (1916)

The Aerial Target (1916) represents one of the earliest and most significant milestones in the history of unmanned aerial vehicle (UAV) development. It was developed by A. M. Low in the United Kingdom during World War I under the supervision of the Royal Flying Corps and the Royal Navy. Designed as an experimental radio-controlled aircraft, the Aerial Target aimed to explore the feasibility of using unmanned aircraft for air defense operations, particularly as a means to intercept enemy zeppelins and aircraft without endangering pilots.

Technically, the Aerial Target was a small, powered fixed-wing air-craft equipped with a radio control system that received commands from a ground-based transmitter. The radio receiver on board was connected to servo-operated control surfaces – such as the rudder and elevators – that allowed the operator to guide the aircraft remotely. This innovation made the Aerial Target the first successful attempt at a powered, remotely controlled flight, establishing the foundational principle of radio-guided control in aviation.

Although it never entered active military service due to limited range, signal instability, and early technological constraints, the project was highly influential. It demonstrated that remote piloting was technically achievable, proving that aircraft could be controlled from the ground without a human pilot onboard (Campbell, 2008).

The Aerial Target (1916) thus holds historical importance as a pioneering step in UAV technology, setting the stage for subsequent developments such as the *Kettering Bug (1918)* and *Queen Bee (1935)*. It symbolized the beginning of the transition from human-operated flight to the concept of unmanned and autonomous aerial systems a revolutionary idea for its time.